It's truly game on for Election 2024. Just as Prime Minister Narendra Modi was basking in the afterglow of having pulled off a successful G20 summit, the Canada chapter only a minor blip in the narrative, and bowled a googly with the Women's Reservation Bill in a special session of Parliament, which sent his personal popularity ratings soaring, Bihar chief minister and Janata Dal (United) patriarch Nitish Kumar has hit a sixer that has the BJP stumped for the moment. On October 2, the birth anniversary of the man who championed the cause of the Harijan, Nitish chose to make public the results of the Bihar Jaati Adharit Ganana, or the Bihar caste-based census. Though couched as a victory for social justice, there was no disguising the political nature of the move.

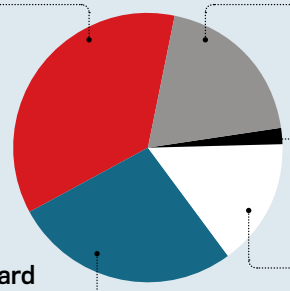
The Bihar caste survey confirms what everyone has suspected for a while now. That OBCs, or the Other Backward Classes, number more than the 52 per cent enumerated in the 1931 census (which formed the basis of the Mandal Commission report in 1980), strengthening the argument that their share in reservations is far less than they should be entitled to. OBCs and EBCs (Extremely Backward Classes) constitute 63.1 per cent of the state's population, the Bihar census has revealed. SCs and STs together account for 21.3 per cent while the forward castes make up the remaining 15.5 per cent. Across the country, SCs and STs together have 22.5 per cent res-

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

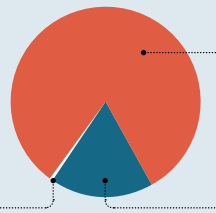
BIHAR'S CASTE COUNT

OF ITS 209 NOTIFIED CASTES, INCLUDING TRANSGENDER, 112 ARE EXTREMELY BACKWARD CLASSES, 34 OTHER BACKWARD CLASSES, 23 SCHEDULED CASTES AND 32 SCHEDULED TRIBES. FOUR HINDU CASTES (RAJPUT, KAYASTHA, BRAHMIN AND BHUMIHAR) AND THREE MUSLIM ONES (SHEIKH, PATHAN AND SYED) HAVE BEEN NOTIFIED AS UNRESERVED OR GENERAL

CASTE BREAK-UP



SHARE BY RELIGION



AMONG THE OBCs, THE YADAVS ACCOUNT FOR **14.26 PER CENT** OF THE STATE'S POLUPATION

WHO GETS HOW MUCH IN BIHAR

Category-wise share in reserved government jobs

